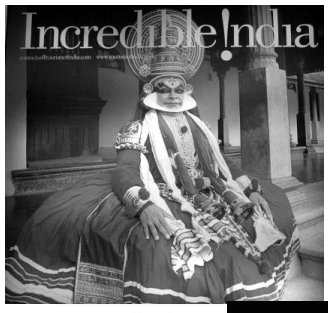
Destination Branding: Tracking Brand India

Dr. Monica Khanna [1]



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Abstract

Destination branding is amongst the most complex branding process, as the stakeholders include both the public and private organizations, local residents and the citizens staying abroad. Developing Brand India is a daunting task. Various initiatives for building brand India like the Incredible India Campaign, India Brand Equity Foundation and India Everywhere Campaign launched at the World Economic Forum at Davos 2006 have been undertaken in India.

The purpose of this research paper is to find out whether these various initiatives resulted in developing a better Brand India. The research paper also tries to find out the perception of brand India among one of its important stakeholders - the Global Indians and the Non Resident Indian. Secondary data regarding the various branding initiatives has been collected and an exploratory survey with the help of a questionnaire has been conducted among the Global Indians and the Non Resident Indians with a sample size of twenty-one respondents. Sample was selected on the basis of convenient sampling.

It was established on the basis of the exploratory survey with the help of a questionnaire that as compared to other countries (except Africa and Bangladesh), India compares poorly on many parameters. India is better as compared to other countries in terms of social & religious tolerance and job opportunities. The media also needs to play a very positive role in creating a vibrant brand India.

For developing a destination brand, it is important to understand the underlying economic, political and social issues, as also the perceptions of the stakeholders of the destination brand. If this is not done, the destination branding exercise becomes a purely promotional exercise with not much benefits accruing to the stakeholders. This is true in today's context more than ever due to the economic, social and political instability in many regions of the world.

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Key Words

Importance of destination branding, measuring destination brand perceptions amongst stake-holders, comparing destination branding initiatives, developing a destination brand

1. Introduction

According to the American Marketing Association, a Brand is a " name, term, sign, symbol, design, or a combination of them, intended to identify the goods and services of one seller or a group of sellers and to differentiate them from those of competition"(Keller,2007)[1]. However, brands go much beyond the connotation of type and source of identification. Brands evoke familiarity and feelings in the minds of the consumer (both positive and negative) and reputation and revenue (both positive and negative) for the company that creates the brand. The most important aspect of the process of brand management is to give out consistent messages and remain relevant not only to the current target group of customers, but also to the future group of customers. This is a great challenge for any company due to changing consumer behavior of the current and future group of customers, competition, and availability of substitute products.

Brand management in the context of a destination becomes even more challenging and complex. In an article by J.Gnoth (2002)[2] that appeared in the Journal of Brand Management, destination branding is the management process which leads to a strategic plan to build brand identity based upon destination attributes selected on the basis of competitiveness, uniqueness and desired identity. So what makes a destination brand different from a regular product or service brand? Evaluating the destination brand and product / service brand on the 4P's of marketing, the differences could be put forth as follows:

Table 1: Differences Between Destination Brand and Product/Service Brand

Parameter	Destination Brand	Product / Service Brand
Type of customers	Many (residents / non residents / tourists / traders / governments	Generally a single group of customers
Expectations from the brand	Different customer groups have different expectations from the destination brand	Uniform expectations from the brand
Comparison with other brands	Difficult	Easy - as there could be direct substitutes for the product / service brand under consideration
Communication strategy	Different messages for different groups of customers	Same message for all groups of customers
Pricing strategy	Not relevant	Can develop a unique pricing strategy
Positioning strategy	Can develop on one or more aspect of the destination brand - tourism / trade / investments	Unique positioning strategy
Distribution Strategy	Use various channels to attract customers to the destination brand	Use various channels to sell and make available the product / service brand.
Association of the customer with the brand	Very long term (for all customer types - for traders and investors it would be for their financial association, for tourists the memories that are associated with the destination)	Length of association depends upon many market ing variables like product / service quality, competition, quality of substitutes, perceived necessity, product / service category etc.

1.1 Brand India : Different Perceptions, Unique Identity

When thinking about what India is, the story that comes to mind is that of the Six Blind Men and the Elephant. All the six blind men touched different parts of the elephants' body and came to different conclusions about the elephant - one thought it was a rope, one a snake, one perceived the elephant to be a pillar and so on. The moral of the story is that perceptions really matter and different people view the same object differently, depending upon the type and level of their interaction with the object.

A random survey regarding perceptions about India reveals distinctly different viewpoints. Some call it as the land of tigers & snake charmers, maharajas & princesses, some as the IT hub of the world, some as the land where yoga, non violence, different religions like Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism originated, some view it as a place of abject poverty and deprivation. A culturally diverse nation having an almost five thousand year old heritage, India is also popularly called as organized chaos. Once upon a time India was called as the Sone Ki Chidiya - Bird of Gold and attracted invaders and mercenaries that looted her wealth and made it their home. It appears that the cycle of time has turned a full circle as the Mckinsey Global Institute released a report in the month of May 2007 on India, with the title The Bird of Gold : The Rise of India's Consumer Market.

Symbols That Created Imagery For Brand India: The Air India Maharajah

Figure - 1[3] **Figure - 2**[4]

One of the best known symbols by which India was recognized abroad, the Air India Maharajah made his first appearance in the airline's advertisements in 1946. The Maharajah came to being thanks to Bobby Kooka - Air India's Commercial Director at that time and Umesh Rao - a designer with the well known designer house in Bombay, J Walter Thompson Ltd. According to Bobby Kooka 'We call him a Maharajah for want of a better description. But his blood isn't blue. He may look like royalty, but he isn't royal.' The naughty diminutive Maharajah of Air India became a world figure and took the sales and promotional message of Air India to millions of travelers across the world, at the same time becoming the most recognized symbol of India abroad. He could be a lover boy in Paris, a sumo wrestler in Tokyo, a pavement artist, a Red Indian, a monk... he could effortlessly flirt with the beauties of the world. And most importantly, he could get away with it all. Simply because he was the Maharajah! The Maharajah and his immense success led to his inclusion in Air India's advertising for the next sixty years. After the merger of Air India and Indian Airlines, the Maharajah was replaced by a new symbol for the combined airlines. (Refer Annexure - I).

Symbols That Created Imagery For Brand India: The Common Man

Figure - 3[5]

Another representation of India was The Common Man created by cartoonist R .K. Laxman for one of the oldest newspaper The Times of India. The daily trials and tribulations that the common man in India has to face are brilliantly represented in R K Laxman's cartoons. So popular and integral to The Times of India was The Common Man, that he featured in a commemorative postage stamp released by the Indian Postal Service on the 150th anniversary of The Times of India in 1988.[6] A 10-foot high bronze statue of "The Common Man" has also been erected at the Symbiosis Institute Pune; India.[7] The Common Man has a wisp of white hair that is perpetually standing, leaving him with a bewildered look. (Refer Annexure - II).

1.2 Govt. of India efforts to develop brand India: The Incredible India Campaign

Figure - 4[8]

Even though the brain drain from India to the developed nations was an on-going phenomenon, it was only during the decade of the 1990's that India started getting its due recognition abroad due to the IT professionals.

A concerted effort to market India abroad by the Govt of India as a hot spot tourist destination began in the year 2002. " A formal marketing initiative called as the Incredible India campaign was conceptualized in the year 2002 by V Sunil (while he was Creative Director, O&M Delhi), and Amitabh Kant, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Tourism, in order to create a distinctive brand identity for India. This resulted in the iconic "Incredible!ndia" logo, where the exclamation mark that formed the "I" of India was used to great effect across all communications. The campaign successfully established India as a high-end tourist destination, generating a 16% increase in tourist traffic in the first year of its launch in the year 2002." [9]

Recognizing the great biodiversity and culture of India which was unexploited for attracting international tourists, and also the ability of tourism to become an engine of economic growth - due to its ability to generate growth and employment in other sectors of the economy, the Government of India developed the National Tourism Policy in the year 2002. [10] [11]

The objective of the National Tourism Policy was to position India as a global brand to take advantage of the burgeoning global travel trade and vast untapped potential of India as a destination. Another objective was to develop tourism in a systematic manner and position it as a major engine of economic growth, to harness its direct and multiplier effects for employment and poverty eradication in an environmentally sustainable manner, and give impetus to rural tourism. Tourism has the capacity to create substantial job opportunities, particularly for unskilled and semi-skilled workers of India, handicrafts, local travel companies, travel agents and others directly or indirectly related to the tourism industry.

The outcomes of the Incredible India campaign were that the share of India in international tourist arrivals progressively increased from 0.46% in the year 2004 to 0.49% in the year 2005 and further to an estimated 0.52 % in 2006 and 0.55% in the year 2007. Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTA) rose from 3.46 million in the year 2004 to an estimated 5 million in the year 2007. Tourism made a significant contribution to India's foreign exchange earnings, which grew from US $ 6.17 billion (Rs 27944 crore) in the year 2004 to an estimated US $ 6.17 billion (Rs 49413 crore) in the year 2007. [12] (Refer to Annexure - III) for pictures of Incredible India.

1.3 Govt. of India Efforts to Develop Brand India: Incredible India - Rural Tourism Scheme

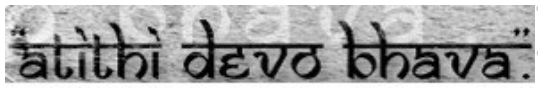
Figure - 5[13]

In the year 2006, the Govt of India Ministry of Tourism partnered with the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) to develop 31 villages across the country to showcase our unique Indian traditions. Activities included setting up common facility centers for crafts persons, and village kala Kendras (art centres) that showcase the cultural and lived heritage of the identified sites. [14]

The project is being executed by the Ministry of Tourism in partnership with implementing partners, mainly NGOs and in select cases, panchayats (village level governing body). This scheme identifies villages for improvement of infrastructure at the selected village, landscaping, parks development, illumination, roads, sewerage systems etc, procurement of equipment related to water sports, adventure sports, eco friendly modes of transport for moving within the tourism zone, refurbishment of the monuments, signages, reception centers, tourist accommodation and other activities directly related to tourism.

The Rural Tourism Project launched under the Incredible India campaign received global recognition by winning the World Travel Award 2006 for the "World's Leading Responsible Tourism Project". [15]

1.4 Govt. of India Efforts to Develop Brand India: Incredible India - Atithi Devo Bhava (Guest is God Scheme)



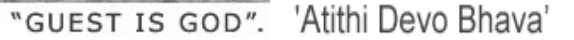


Figure - 6 [16] **Figure - 7** [16] **Figure - 8** [16]

'Atithi Devo Bhavah' i.e. Guest is God, launched under the aegis of the Incredible India campaign, is a social awareness campaign aimed at providing the inbound tourist a sense of being welcomed into the country. The campaign targets the general public as a whole, while focusing mainly on the stakeholders of the tourism industry. The main components of the campaign are training and orientation to taxi drivers, guides, immigration officers, tourist police and other personnel directly interacting with the tourists. Leading media personalities Aamir Khan and Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra have been roped in as brand ambassadors for spreading the message of Atithi Devo Bhava.

Smt. Renuka Chowdhury, Minister of State for Tourism with the government of India during the years 2004-09 said 'Atithi Devo Bhavah' is a nationwide campaign aimed at sensitizing people about India's rich cultural heritage, its preservation, cleanliness, hospitality and bringing out an attitudinal shift among the masses towards tourists. It is a symbolic representation of India's age old hospitality and with this campaign; we are trying to re-install in the stakeholders a sense of pride and responsibility towards tourists, while positioning India as a popular tourist destination worldwide." [17] Ministry of Tourism has also launched the website on Atithi Devo Bhava http://atithi.org.in, to bring about attitudinal shifts on how people of India should treat tourists and stop the menace of graffiti on national monuments. The website solicits the website viewers' suggestions on both of the above.

1.5 Govt. of India Efforts to Develop Brand India: India Brand Equity Foundation

Figure - 9 [18]

An initiative of the Ministry of Commerce & Industry to create Brand India, the vehicle for this purpose was the creation of the India Brand Equity Fund (IBEF) in the year 1996 with a corpus of Rs 50 crore. The corpus was raised to Rs 156 crore in the year 2002. The objective was to disburse loans to help certain companies to build greater awareness for their products in the international markets. Towards the end of the year 2002, the working of IBEF was transferred to the Confederation of Indian Industries (CII) and the India Brand Equity Fund was re-christened as the India Brand Equity Foundation. [19] This meant that the focus of IBEF would not be just assisting companies in building their brands, but also focuses on the country per se and develops

an India country brand strategy. Other government departments like the ministry of external affairs and tourism ministry would also be involved in the working of India Brand Equity Foundation. The whole focus of IBEF is to "Celebrate India" as a "Destination of Opportunities and Ideas" with very specific objectives. The website www.ibef.org is an India Resource Center and provides inputs on various Indian parameters like trade and economy, states of India, industry etc.

1.6 Govt. of India Efforts to Develop Brand India: India Everywhere Campaign -World Economic Forum 2006

Figure - 10 [20]

India everywhere at Davos 2006

The CII launched the India Everywhere campaign at the World Economic Forum (WEF) at Davos from Jan 25-29, 2006. The high powered Indian team comprised of Cabinet Ministers, Chief Ministers, and Prominent Indian Business Leaders, in order to deliver a single message to the global community "India - the fastest growing free market democracy". [21] Over a hundred participants were there from India at Davos 2006. The World Economic Forum's annual meet in Davos is the most important business event in the world where over two thousand global leaders congregate to shape global, regional & industry agenda and to find solutions to global challenges.

Indian business and government leaders spent two years and more than US $ 4 million to put together an elaborate marketing and public relations campaign - just like an MNC - to ensure that the "India Story" got a prominent play and did not get lost amid the clutter at Davos 2006. The US $4 million campaign was funded by contributions from twenty two Indian companies. The Indian government spent another US $ 2 million through the IBEF under its commerce ministry, which worked closely with the CII on putting together the "India Everywhere" campaign.

The core message of the "India Everywhere" campaign was to present India as an attractive destination for foreign investment, as an emerging manufacturing hub and as a credible partner for world business. In addition, it highlighted the Indian Govt's policy reforms and showcased the country's cultural diversity, with the overall goal of helping Davos participants gain a deeper understanding of Indian people and markets.

1.7 What is Brand India in the Year 2009?

The story of the Six Blind Men and the Elephant again comes to mind - so how does the world perceive India in the year 2009? Though beautiful images of India have been put forth through the various initiatives like the Incredible India campaign, IBEF initiatives and the India Everywhere campaign, the reality about India is very harsh.

Security has turned out to be a serious issue of concern after the Mumbai 2008 terrorist attacks, and the image of India took a further beating after the huge corporate scandal involving India's

leading software company Satyam Computers. Serious issues relating to poverty, corruption, insurgencies, rural-urban divide and lax corporate governance worry India as it unfurls its plans to emerge as the leading nation of the world.

Failed States Index - a collaboration between The Fund for Peace, an independent research organization, and Foreign Policy use 12 indicators of state cohesion and performance, to rank 177 states in order from most to least at risk of failure. India lies in the warning zone and ranks 87th on the list. [22]

1.8 How do Stakeholders Perceive Brand India?

A questionnaire for conducting an exploratory research was prepared and a survey conducted among the Global Indians (those who travel frequently abroad for work and leisure) and the Non Resident Indians. The Global Indians and NRI's are important stakeholders for brand India, as they carry the message of India abroad, and help India to attract investments and tourists. Every Global Indian and Non Resident Indian acts as India's ambassador abroad, carrying along with him/her the social, cultural and economic status of India. The sample size for the exploratory survey was of 21 respondents and the selection was through convenient sampling method - those Indians who travelled abroad frequently for work and leisure or NRI's.

The profile of the respondents surveyed was: 80% were male; more than 60% were engineering graduates with a post graduate degree in management and were liberal Indians in their attitude. 80% were Global Indians (having travelled extensively abroad for work or leisure) and their regular food habits were Indian. Chinese was the most preferred foreign food, and more than 80% belonged to the age group 35 years and above. Regarding the question as to how did they perceived India as compared to the other countries in terms of the various parameters, the answers were as follows:

Table 2: Perception of India vis -a- vis Other Countries On Various Parameters

Parameter	Worse than India	Same as India	Better than India
Law and Order	Africa	16%	70%
Cleanliness	Africa,		92%
Condition of Roads	Africa		92%
Job Opportunities	23%, Africa	31%	31%
Electrical power Supply	Africa	1%	77%
Poverty	*		69%
Social & Religious Tolerance	15%, @	46%	23%
Opportunities for Growth	23%	23%, Latin America	38%, Africa
Quality of Education	15%, Africa, Kuwait	31%	54%, Europe and US, Canada
Health facilities	Africa	1%	77%, Europe and US but costly

(Bangladesh is the only country that is worse than India on all the above parameters)

* varies from country to country, Africa is bad.

@ racism still observed in few countries, religion-wise, more tolerant in Europe but much less in Africa.

From the above table, it can be observed that as far as infrastructure issues are concerned, the other countries are perceived to be better (on parameters of law and order, cleanliness, condi-

tions of roads, electrical power supply , quality of education and health facilities). Poverty is less as compared to India. The redeeming factor for India is that social and religious tolerance is perceived to be better than other countries. The respondents were divided on the parameter of opportunities for growth but the majority felt that it is the same or better than India.

Regarding the responsibility for developing various infrastructures in India, the respondents have clearly stated that revamping the police force, removal of slums from cities and development of villages should be government initiatives, whereas development of power sector, roads, education and health should be equally a government and private sector initiative. Respondents were divided in their opinion regarding tourism but felt that it should be more of a private initiative and less of a government initiative, and hotels should be purely private sector initiatives.

Regarding government policy being different for rural and urban India, the views expressed were they should be different for education, and specifically the television programmes regarding health & hygiene, education & entertainment should be different.

The question regarding how India should combat terrorism revealed very firm vies on the subject. Most of the respondents felt that terrorism could be tackled by having a better intelligence network, enacting strict laws for persons indulging in such activities, and creating an " alert citizen " movement to combat terrorism.

How could media be used to create a strong and vibrant India? Some of the answers were: "A responsible media is amongst the best medicines for India right now. With the kind of media options available currently, unlike any other time in our history, with its reach and scope, it can bring about socio-cultural changes that best meet the aspirations of the current and future generations. It can play as much role in rural education as it can in eradicating social injustices and create social bonding. This will help in many ways including, in some ways, combating terrorism. However, it's got to be a responsible media." "Media should be used to highlight corruption, develop India as a business destination and tourism including medical tourism."

1.9 What Should be Brand India Focus - Tourism or Trade?

Just like in the story of the Six Blind Men and the Elephant, Brand India can mean anything to anyone or everything to someone - it should focus on everything - building its equity not only in tourism but also trade - therein lies the beauty and mystic of India. In the final analysis, Brand India means a destination full of opportunities, just waiting to be explored. As Dr A. P. J. Adbul Kalam has rightly said "To succeed in your mission, you must have single-minded devotion to your goal"[23].

In the closing remarks, I would like to mention how Mark Twain has very aptly described India: "The one land that all men desire to see and having seen once, by even a glimpse, would not give the glimpse for all the shows of all the rest of the globe combined"[24].

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